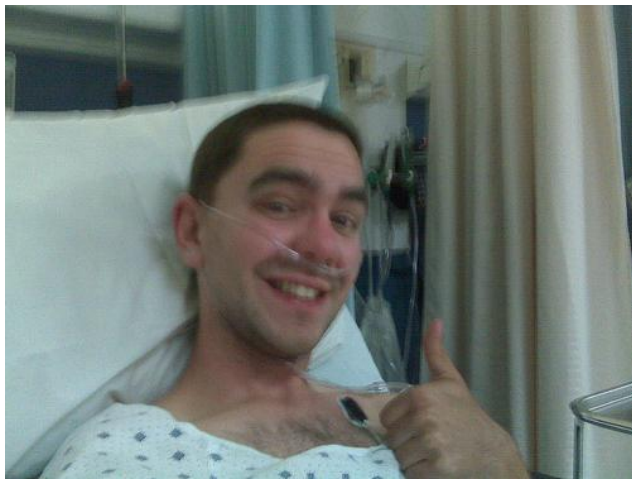


In this very special edition of Matt dragging his butt up every high mountain he can manage, how to go from...



...to...



...in less than a day.

Climbing Mt Lyell and Mt Maclure

The weekend started like usual with me flying in to Orange County at 6 pm from Boise. The difference was that this time I actually had someone willing to carpool with me so when I left my apartment at 8 pm it was to drive out to meet David Sha at his house.

At roughly 9 pm we started north and after trading off driving a few times we pulled into a parking lot at Yosemite around 3 am. Due to the no camping signs in evidence we just leaned the car seats back and slept for a few hours in the car. It was about as comfortable as it sounds.

8 am we met with the leaders and other participants and headed off down the John Muir Trail / Pacific Crest Trail.



The fact we were on the overlap section of these two trails meant there were a large number of thru hikers heading through the area. The PCT folks were headed north and some had been on the trail for several months. In fact our group even recognized a few from down near the Mexican border when we were there for the kickoff.



JMT folks were headed south and were a much softer bunch. Instead of being 900 miles in to a 2600 mile journey they were at mile 5 of a 220 mile walk. Many of them were younger and had much heavier gear than even we were carrying for our peak climb.



The majority of the hike in was along the relatively flat Lyell Canyon. It was pretty enough and the water flowing down the center was amazingly clear. We had to resist the urge to stop and go for a swim, something we saw other hikers taking advantage of at several points with varying amounts of clothing.



The trail itself was obviously heavily used with several ruts running parallel in places where foot traffic had been periodically diverted.

Also there were a number of stream crossings only some of which had a bridge or other easily passable route.



Eventually we started climbing towards Donahue Pass. We had a few thousand feet to gain before we would leave the trail and strike out towards the peaks to find a camping spot that would put us in a good position for the following day.



We did have one fun stream crossing where we actually had to remove our boots and wade across. Well, actually everyone else did; due to the fact I was wearing trail runners I just tromped through and let them dry naturally.



Finally we were done with the crowded trail and headed cross county up a drainage. This involved a mix of rock hopping and crossing snow fields that were interesting to maneuver with a pack.





We came to our plateau at about 10,700 ft and hunted around for campsites. Most people set up on bare rock while I went for the only slightly soggy grass. There was water everywhere due to the melting snow above. So much for peeing 200 ft from a water source...

We had a marmot that seemed to live in the area we set up camp. He would watch us and circle around getting quite close so we were all keeping an eye on our food.



He seemed quite happy to pose for pictures.



We had the traditional Sierra Club happy hour and turned in early as the sun went down and the temperature dropped.



I slept extremely well that first night. I awoke only once due to some wind gusts that sent my tent flapping and marveled at what looked like a spotlight focused on my tent. Sticking my head outside I realized it was a very full and very bright moon which made everything very easy to see. Too bad we didn't plan a night hike.



The next morning at 6:45 am we had our daypacks on and were ready to charge up the mountain. This was going to be a technical climb so we all had helmets, ice axes, and crampons in our bags.

We ran into one other group on the way up who had climbed Lyell the previous day. They were a bunch of 20-something males who had gone up without helmets or ice axes using the softer snow to make their way. Just a bit on the risky side.



We started up the steep snow to approach the peaks and found a field of sun cups (sun melted indentations in the snow) which made for easy climbing since they could almost be used as stairs. At this point the helmets and ice axes were put into use but the crampons remained in the bag.



After an easy jaunt we were looking up at our first target, Lyell Mountain. At 13,114 ft Lyell is the high point of Yosemite and requires either a snow climb across a glacier or a class 3 or 4 rock climb.

We went for the snow climb initially and when it became steep and icy started to cut steps with our axes. This was proving somewhat dicey and it was decided to jump onto the rock section. This made me happy as I'm a big fan of rock.



The rock was mostly class 3 though a fall would have resulted in quite a quite spectacular descent at some points. We reached one particular crux where we roped up as a precaution using a bowline on a coil in place of a harness. Once we were all past that section it was a mix of rock scrambling and snow fields until we made the top.



An interesting feature of the peak was the summit register box which had been installed back in 1935.



The register inside didn't go back nearly as far of course but it's still neat to find an artifact like that.



Yeehaw!



Descending from Lyell the leader decided to avoid the rope section and take us down the steep snow / ice section. Following his lead we used our ice axes to self anchor and kicked in footsteps to climb down.





I liked the leader's statement before we started: "This is a time when you want to be careful and not make any mistakes."

Once we were down on an easier slope we were able to sit down and glissade down. Others did a bit better than me as the ice was such that I ended up using my axe to self arrest to avoid accelerating out of control. Ah well, good practice if a bit hard on my new camera.



Now it was time for peak #2, Maclure. This was going to be a straight rock climb though we had to switchback up some snow initially.



The rocks on Maclure could best be described as shattered and several sections had many loose pieces requiring extra care. In addition there were points where you were looking at a drop of several thousand feet right below you. This was as opposed to maybe a 50 foot drop, a bounce off some rocks, and a long slide down into the snow bowl on the other side. It kept me from getting bored 😊

After the false starts and difficulties on Lyell the climb up Maclure went surprisingly fast. Again we were sitting on the summit enjoying far reaching views marred only by an apparent fire in the distance.





Descent was also straight forward with the added bonus of when we reached the snow being able to glissade down. This worked to varying degrees depending on the slope and by the time we were to camp my pants were thoroughly soaked but it was very fun.





We returned to camp tired but victorious.

Acute Mountain Sickness or quite possibly HAPE?

So up until this point the weekend had been going great. I had started the trip with some initial concerns about my left heel which was inflamed from a previous trip but that had proven to be unfounded. The weather had been great, and we had made both of our peaks.

When we returned to camp I was tired but energized by the day's activity. While some in the group turned in early or took naps I was hopping around on rocks taking pictures of the PCT/JMT thru hikers camped below us.

The wind started picking up and we all went to bed sometime around 8 pm. At that point things took a definite turn for the worse.

I laid down in my tent and I don't remember how much later it was when the problems started. At some point in the next few hours I started to have a nasty cough and I noticed when I forced all the

breath out of my lungs there was a cracking noise not unlike when I've had bronchitis in the past. It was getting harder to breath and generally felt like my lungs were slowly filling up with fluid.

I found I could only lay certain ways because if I was flat on my back or to one side I would start a coughing fit.

At some point I went outside to pee. At first I was stumbling a bit then I remember suddenly looking at the dirt about an inch from my face. I'd fallen over and very nearly passed out. I had a black circle in the center of my vision and I ended up curled up on the ground for a bit before I could stand, finish my business, and stagger back into my tent.

The wind kept up so that it was the middle of the night, I was isolated in a tent at 11,000 ft that was flapping all over the place due to the gusts, and the nearest potential help was over 10 miles and several thousand feet down.

As the night wore on the feeling of my lungs filling up continued and I increasingly felt like I couldn't get enough oxygen. In addition the positions that had given me some respite from the cough a few hours ago were no longer working.

I vaguely remember my face hurting but I wasn't thinking completely straight and it wouldn't be until the next day in the ER I'd realize that had been a headache, one of the major signs of altitude sickness.

I also remember at one point sweating yet being convinced I was freezing cold.

Somehow I managed to get a small amount of sleep sometime before dawn because my alarm woke me at 5 am.

I informed the leaders of the rough night I had and the continuing symptoms though I still described the cough as if I had bronchitis. Since the plan was to descend that day there was nothing to be done but pack up and get started.

Unfortunately I was having a hard time feeling like I had enough oxygen while sitting or laying down. Putting on a 40 pound pack and walking over 10 miles proved to be a very miserable experience. Even the slightest of inclines resulted in me slowing down to a crawl and gasping for breath. I was also stumbling and had to concentrate on getting one foot in front of the other.

On the plus side it was pretty out. Not that I was able to appreciate it much at the time.



After unbearably long hours of hiking we made it back to the car. At that point I dropped my pack and sat with my back against David's car trying to catch my breath to no avail. I had ask David put my pack in the car and it was a major ordeal just walking across the parking lot to thank the leaders.

As we started the ~6 hour drive home I was still having problems breathing just sitting in the passenger seat. If anything it had gotten worse since descending from altitude that morning. The drive home consisted of a few mountain towns then a long drive through no man's land so finally I decided to stop at the Bishop ER.

They were a small operation, one doctor and 5 beds, and they took me right away and put me on oxygen. Initial x-rays showed what looked like pneumonia in my right lung and they thought I might have High Attitude Pulmonary Edema which is a rather bad thing to have in the pantheon of mountain related illnesses.



I now had a good 4 or 5 hours of observation with an oxygen tube in my nose and an infernally beeping screen displaying the oxygen saturation of my blood (FYI, you can make graph do all sorts of interesting things by squeezing the finger sensor.) Then at last the doctor came in and declared that the radiologist didn't know what they were doing and there was no pneumonia. He diagnosed me with Acute Mountain Sickness and said I should be able to leave soon. The cough was better and the feeling of fluid in my lungs was greatly reduced.

Being able to breathe is a beautiful thing when you've been deprived of it for a time.

About 9 pm I was finally discharged and my very patient carpool partner and I were able to start the long drive back to Orange County. Unfortunately I was under strict instructions not to drive due to allegedly not being right in the head so he had to drive the entire way.

We arrived back at David's around 2 am where the ever patient Kim arrived to pick me up and drive me back to my apartment.

So in summary, a damn good weekend other than that whole being stranded first at 11k ft not able to breathe and having to go to the ER thing. Can't have everything I suppose ☺

Next weekend I'll be solo backpacking somewhere out in the mountains north of Boise which should prove to be a interesting change in scenery.